



mind—meaning that female soldiers fight to prove themselves to their peers. In 2013, when the US ban was lifted, Marine Corps Captain Katie Petronio wrote against the decision, claiming that continuous combat operations took a toll on women's bodies that far outweighed the toll on men.

Women in combat also face the same challenges as service members in auxiliary positions did a century before in terms of how they are treated by male colleagues. While military service is rewarding for many who enlist, women have to contend with assault, harassment, and rape. Interviewed in 2017, North Korean soldier Lee So Yeon claimed that rape was a fact of life for women in combat, but that nobody was ever willing to testify against their superiors. A similar culture was evidenced in *The Invisible War* (2012), a documentary on sexual assault within the US military—an issue that is still a problem in gender-integrated military units worldwide. Ironically, the threat of having female prisoners of war raped by the enemy continues to be a reason given against allowing women into combat positions, with critics arguing that male soldiers' morale would suffer from seeing their female comrades assaulted.



► Guns at the ready

A female Swedish soldier participates in a joint training exercise between Swedish and Russian forces in December 2007. Since 1989, all positions in the Swedish military have been open to women.

PROFILES

SISTERS IN ARMS

Maria Wittek (1899–1997) was the first female general in the history of the Polish military. She served as the leader of *Przysposobienie Wojskowe Kobiet* (Female Military Training), which prepared young girls for military life. In 1919, Wittek fought against Bolshevik forces in Ukraine, and in 1920, served in the defense of Lviv, earning the highest Polish honor: the *Virtuti Militari*.

Lina Odena (1911–1936) was a *miliciana* (a female combatant) in the Spanish Civil War of 1936 to 1939. From the beginning, Odena served as a leader of the anti-fascist resistance, organizing and commanding militias. She died on a reconnaissance mission on the Granada front; surrounded by the enemy, she shot herself in the head to keep her secrets and avoid becoming a prisoner of war.

Sabiha Gökçen (1913–2001) was the first Turkish woman to serve as a combat pilot, and the first woman in the world to be a fighter pilot. An adopted child of Turkish revolutionary Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, Gökçen was given a military education on his orders, and flew in combat for the first time during the Dersim rebellion of 1937. She earned a medal and a letter of appreciation for damage caused by her bombs during the operation.

Simone Segouin (b. 1925) is a former French resistance fighter who went by the *nom de guerre* Nicole Minet during World War II. She joined *Francs-Tireurs et Partisans Français*, a group of communists and nationalists, at the age of 18, and captured 25 German prisoners of war during the liberation of Chartres. She was awarded the prestigious *Croix de Guerre*.

Solveig Krey (b. 1963) of the Norwegian Navy became the world's first female captain of a military submarine in 1995, at the helm of the 485-ton KNM *Kobben*. Norway first allowed women to serve on its submarines in 1985; many nations still prohibit this. In 2012, she became commander-in-chief of the Norwegian submarine fleet.

Sergeant Leigh Ann Hester (b. 1982) is a soldier in the National Guard (military police) of the United States Army. She earned a Silver Star for her actions in Iraq in 2005, becoming the first American woman to win one in combat, and was the first to be valorized for close quarters combat, after killing three insurgents with grenades and maneuvering her troops to safety in a firefight.